

Control Vista with your voice

Did you know you can control Vista with your voice alone? Read on to find out how

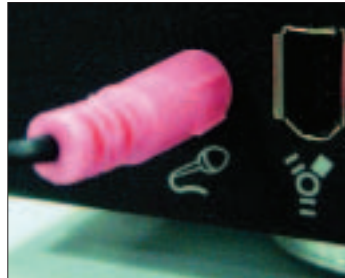
Speech recognition software lets you control your computer by speaking to it. Before Vista came along, you had to install extra software if you wanted to use speech recognition. Now, with a bit of patience, some speakers and a microphone, you can tell your PC what to do without spending extra cash.

We found that speech recognition worked particularly well when dictating letters in Word and Wordpad, but you can also use it to navigate around your computer, send emails and even surf the internet. It does take some patience and is not as quick as using a keyboard and mouse, but it is liberating to be able to control your computer hands-free.

By the time you complete this Workshop, you will have learnt how to set up a microphone, and your computer will be following your spoken commands.

Step 1

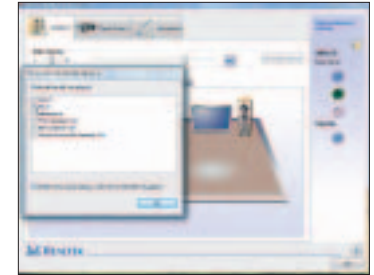
A headset with a microphone works particularly well with speech recognition, as it gives you the freedom to move away from your desk and to work hands-free. These start from about approximately Rs. 432 and are available from any good electronics shop. If you have the more expensive sort of headset that works via USB, you can plug it into a free USB port on either the front or back of your PC. Got a non-USB headset? Insert the mic plug into the pink port on the back of your PC (it may have a microphone logo next to it). If you've got a standalone microphone, just plug it into the pink mic-in port.



Step 2

When you plug in the mic, a box should appear on screen.

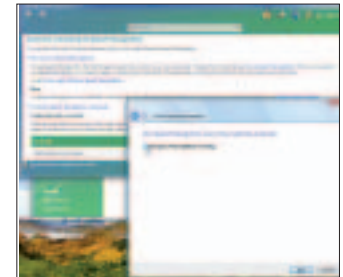
If it doesn't, go to Start > Control Panel > Hardware and Sound > Manage Audio Devices > Recording. Make sure 'Mic in' is ticked and then click OK > click OK again. Check that you have switched your microphone on and its volume control is set to a reasonable level. If you are using a headset, make sure it is not on mute. Now you are going to check that your microphone is working properly. Click Start > Control Panel > Ease of Access > then Speech Recognition.



Step 3

In the Speech Recognition Options box, click 'Start Speech Recognition'. In the next box, select your mic. Click Next and Next again. Say the on-screen instructions and click Next. If Next is greyed out, skip to Step 4. If you do not speak clearly, you will get a message telling you so. If so, click the Back button in the top left of the box. When you see the message, 'Your microphone is now set up', click Next. Select 'Enable document review' and click Next. Click View Reference Sheet and then 'Common Speech Recognition Commands' to see the commands you can use.

If all works well, proceed to step 5.



Step 4

If you could not click Next as mentioned in the previous step, double-check your microphone is switched on, has the volume turned up and is plugged in properly. If every-

